

news feed

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hypothesis

Mio 8380

■ What is it?

It is the first cell phone designed by Microsoft and Intel that will be manufactured by Mitac—a Taiwan-based PC manufacturer. Mio will cost between \$565 and \$598. It goes on sale in Europe later this year.

■ What does it comprise?

It uses Microsoft's Smartphone 2002 and Intel's PXA255 200 MHz processor. It is a GSM with a 65,000-colour 2.2-inch TFT-LCD screen. It also has a digital camera with features such as auto-focus and auto-brightness controls. Mio also has PC tools such as Internet Explorer, Outlook and MSN Messenger.

■ Why should I use it?

Mio allows users to do tasks such as managing documents, e-mailing, and downloading multimedia files in the familiar Windows interface. It can play mp3 files and videos in MPEG-4 compression format.

snapshot

35 million
Americans
download
music files
and about
26 million
share files online.

Source: Pew Internet and American Life Project

Unzippin stuck zips

Everybody's favourite compression format, the zip format, may soon be incompatible across different decompression tools. It all started with the introduction of the AES encryption feature in two of the popular zip tools—WinZip and PKZip. PKZip implemented AES encryption, but didn't disclose any details. Later on, when WinZip implemented it, the

resulting encrypted archive turned out to be incompatible. However, by default, WinZip and PKZip use the same non-encrypted version that is compatible with the long-stable standard zip format, and should be usable by all. The encrypted archives though, will not be compatible across different tools, at least for now.



You will either have to avoid using the encryption feature or be sure that the recipients know which tool was used to zip and lock.

Arcade Ahoy!

Though not quite in the league of Electronic Entertainment Expo (E3), the Classic Gaming Expo 2003 that took place over the 9th and 10th August brought together over



1200 vintage gamers to Las Vegas. With the expo celebrating everything about the gaming industry's colourful past—from ancient coin-operated arcade games, to those built for the Apple II, Amiga, Atari 2600 and the Commodore 64—this was a celebration of the history as well as simplicity, charm, and appeal of yesteryear's games. The event also brought together video gaming legends including Activision designer Steve Cartwright and Rob Zydbel, both of whom worked on several Atari VCS game titles. The event's highlights included an exhibition that puts hundreds of ancient gaming devices and memorabilia on display, as well as the chance to play over 50 arcade games for free.

High Speed Wireless Multimedia

The Institute of Electrical and Electronics Engineers (IEEE) has put forth its new 802.15.3 standard for wireless personal area networks (WPAN) that allows data transfer rates up to 55 megabits per second, thus substantially increasing the 1 mbps speed. According to the IEEE, it allows up to 245 wireless devices to be connected within 300 feet.

The distance plays an important role in speed. For a

distance of 300 ft, the transmission speed would be 22 mbps, while for a distance of 165 ft, the users will get the maximum speed of 55 mbps.

This standard has come up due to a demand for connecting multiple devices at low cost and running high-bandwidth applications. In order to minimise costs, the need of external components has been kept low and the required two chips fit within a compact Flash Card.

To phone a Thief

Thieves are now sure to have a tough time selling stolen mobile phones. Phonetrack, launched by Phonetrack Africa Ltd, inserts identification marks, such as the owner's photo-



ILLUSTRATIONS: Mahesh Benkar

graphs and alter-nate phone numbers into the mobile phones permanently. "Our facility configures the handset's motherboard, making it hard to erase the photo

and the alternative phone numbers because doing this would mean destroying the phone," says Ernesta Jalipa, director of Phonetrack.

The company is currently working on a software that would enable it to block the handset in case of theft, by using the phone's serial number. Re-activation of the hand set will be possible after recovery.

